



spiritual relationship with nature, for example, they create sanctuaries for plants and animals, called Galu, near many of their settlements. Other customs though—such as the colorful way they dress—did not

emerge until the 19th century. The Kuna have their own language, also called Kuna. Spanish is their second tongue, and some people—mostly those who trade with tourists—speak a few words of English.



LOBSTER FISHING

At one time, lobster provided the Kuna with dietary protein as well as export revenue. Now, supplies are dwindling, and lobster has become so expensive that local people can't afford it.



SUGAR CANE

Largely agricultural people, the Kuna farm plots of waterside land. Main crops include coconuts, plantains, bananas, and sugar cane, which this matriarch is processing while she puffs on her traditional pipe.

WOVEN CULTURE

One of the best-known Kuna traditions is the making of colorful *molos*—hand-woven panels appliquéd with beautiful patterns or pictures. Although many of them feature authentic folk-art designs, the craft itself is a relatively modern one, inspired by access to both commercial fabrics and, to some degree, images from Western media.



TRADING IN TRADITION

Molas (which were originally intended to be set into women's blouses) are strongly symbolic of Kuna cultural identity, but they are widely valued too by souvenir-hunting tourists and lovers of textile art. Patterns range from graphic shapes and stylized plants and animals, to interpretations of poster images, labels, illustrations, and logos. Resourceful traders use the same technique to produce smaller, more saleable items like bags and pot holders.

